

DELHI | Military Mahabharata



Arjun: Weight: 60 tonne.
Power: 1400 HP.
Cost: Rs 17 crore.

No, it's not yet another soap version of the timeless Mahabharata but the final showdown between the two contenders for the title of Tank No. 1. This June, the Indian Army will conduct comparative field trials between the indigenously-built Arjun main battle tank and the Russian-built T-90 Bheeshma tank in the 40 degree Celsius plus heat of the Thar desert.

Fourteen Bheeshmas will be pitted against an equal number of Arjuns. During the three-day exercises, each tank will fire 50 rounds and traverse 150 km in a test of strength. Given how the Arjuna vs Bheeshma mythological contest ended, the army is hoping for a different conclusion: it is already heavily committed to the Bheeshma, importing over 650 tanks and building 1,000 locally. The long-delayed Arjun though, has had to struggle for acceptance. Only 124 Arjuns will be bought this year and the first regiment of 40 tanks will be commissioned in May. *by Sandeep Unnithan*



Bheeshma (T-90):
Weight: 47 tonne. Power: 900 HP. Cost: Rs 12 crore.



DELHI | Luxury Cruise Aid

One day later this year, it may be possible to look out to the horizon of key Indian ports and witness the arrival of royalty. With the Ministry of Tourism (MoT) clearing a policy to allow port trusts to develop cruise-related infrastructure, luxury liners may touch the Indian shores soon. According to ministry officials, major liners including the *Queen Mary II*, the world's largest luxury liner, are expected to arrive in India around February-March.

The initiative was inaugurated with the smooth conduct of Kochi as a stop during

the recent Volvo ocean race. Developing cruise tourism is estimated to be a good source of revenue. According to an MoT estimate, even if a cruise tourist spends \$45 per port, it could translate into an earning of over Rs 41 crore in the year 2010-2011 and Rs 271 crore by 2030-2031.

The cumulative total earnings from cruise tourists and crew from 2005-06 to 2030-31 is estimated at Rs 2,698 crore. There are some 315 vessels cruising around the world, of which about 150 could call at Indian ports. *by Nandini Valsh*

Game Plan

The LA Clippers vs Portland Trailblazers NBA game on January 26 will also mark the first-ever NBA celebration of India's Republic Day. An Armed Services Honour guard, cultural song and dance and a video address from BJP leader L. K. Advani are part of the fun fund-raiser at Los Angeles's Staples Centre. A portion of the proceeds will be donated to 26/11 victims and their families through the Red Cross.